NewsBank inc.

Ethnic studies curriculum viewed as anti-Semitic

September 5, 2019 | Acorn, The (Agoura Hills, CA)
Author: The Acorn Staff | Section: Front Page | 735 Words
OpenURL Link

Stung by accusations of anti Semitism, the California Board of Education announced that its ethnic-studies curriculum will be dropped in favor of a new model that is more sensitive to the Jewish experience.

The state's Ethnic Studies Model Curriculum that was awaiting approval as a potential high school graduation requirement came under heavy criticism by multiple cities, public school boards and the state Legislature's Jewish Caucus. Opponents of the curriculum say it ignores the history of anti- Semitism and promotes Jewish stereotypes.

The curriculum stressed the importance of studying hate crimes and looked at the rise of white supremacy—but omitted meaningful discussion of anti Semitism, members of the California Legislative Jewish Caucus in a letter to Soomin Chao, chair of the Instructional Quality Commission, the body responsible for drafting the curriculum.

The state education board pulled the document last week for revision.

The City of Agoura Hills sounded an alarm at its Aug. 14 meeting when the City Council joined with state Sen. Henry Stern (D-Calabasas) and Assemblymember Richard Bloom (D-Santa Monica) in their rebuke of the ethnic-studies curriculum drafted by the Department of Education's Instructional Quality Committee.

Agoura Hills Mayor Linda Northrop also wrote to Chao, emphasizing that the document included "blatant omissions, misrepresentations and an anti Jewish bias."

"Agoura Hills has a significant, diverse and thriving Jewish population," Northrop said.

"As such we have seen our unfortunate share of anti-Semitism incidents. As hate crimes continue across the country with increasing violence and frequency, we cannot minimize the experiences of our Jewish communities and the discrimination they face, past and present, locally and beyond."

In his letter to Chao, Las Virgenes Unified School District Superintendent Dan Stepenosky listed several objections to the curriculum, including what he called the commission's "extreme and politically motivated biased point of view" de-legitimizing the existence of the state of Israel as well as equating capitalism, "the foundational element of our economic system," with racism and white supremacy.

Stepenosky said the draft curriculum doesn't present a "balanced perspective on the Israeli-Palestinian conflict."

The superintendent said Las Virgenes is in favor of ethnic studies coursework but only if it's "inclusive, sensitive and supportive of all of our California residents and communities."

The Jewish Caucus condemned the document in detail in its letter to Chao.

"Despite the significant contributions of Jews to California history, politics, culture and government— and our long-standing struggle against hatred and discrimination— the ESMC effectively erases the American Jewish experience," wrote Ben Allen, chair of the Jewish Caucus, and Jesse Gabriel, vice chair.

The exclusions "appeared to be intentional and reflected the political bias of the drafters of the ESMC," the letter stated.

"This glaring omission is deeply troubling, especially against the backdrop of a recent surge in violent antisemitic

incidents, which has included the shooting at the Tree of Life Synagogue in Pittsburgh . . . and the tragic shooting at the Chabad in Poway" in April."

Mathy Wasserman, an LVUSD board member, said the exclusion of anti-Semitism and the American Jewish experience in the model curriculum weren't the only issues that bothered her.

The Armenian genocide that wiped out 1.5 million Armenians, mostly from the Ottoman Empire, between 1915 and 1917, was not mentioned in the document either.

In addition to Armenian groups calling for inclusion in the curriculum, Greeks, Hindus and Koreans are also calling for changes.

Some information included in the document was troubling, Wasserman said; there were references to "capitalism and intellectualism as ways to oppress people."

She said the curriculum "was completely one-sided."

At the Aug. 13 LVUSD school board meeting, board member Dallas Lawrence said the curriculum was "the result of an unchecked fringe view that has polluted its way into the halls of academia and into the offices of career state education bureaucrats.

"It is so far outside the mainstream of even liberal California views that we must all collectively raise our voices in unity to oppose what it represents. It shrouds its entire approach to diversity in a dangerous cloak of ideological extremism and blatant anti-Semitism bent on erasing the Jewish experience from our classrooms. It cannot be allowed to stand unchecked."

The Instructional Quality Commission consists of 18 members, and includes a state senator and an assemblymember. Seven members of the committee were experts in their field of study and seven were required to be K-12 teachers in California.

Chao did not respond to calls from The Acorn requesting comments on how the commission devised the curriculum.

Copyright (c) 2019, Acorn, The (Agoura Hills, CA), All rights reserved

- **Citation (apa Style)**
  Acorn Staff, T. (2019, September 5). Ethnic studies curriculum viewed as anti-Semitic.*Acorn, The (Agoura Hills, CA).* Available from NewsBank: Access World News – Historical and Current: https://infoweb.newsbank.com/apps/news/document-view?p=WORLDNEWS&docref=news/175C3CB237CF5E68.